

Advanced Chama Management System

Frequently Asked Questions

Generated: 01 July 2026 13:55

Version 1.0

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Advanced Chama Management System

General

1. What is a chama?

A chama is an informal savings group, common in Kenya, where members pool money for savings, loans, and investments.

2. What does this system do?

It helps chamas manage members, contributions, loans, shares, meetings, announcements, messaging, accounting, and reports digitally.

3. Is the system free?

Yes, it is self-hosted open-source software. There are no subscription fees.

4. Do I need an internet connection?

Yes, the system runs on a web server and requires a browser with internet access.

5. Can I access it on my phone?

Yes, the responsive layout works on smartphones, tablets, and computers.

Accounts and Login

6. How do I get an account?

Your group administrator creates your account. You will receive your email, password, and group code.

7. What is a group code?

A unique code assigned to your chama group. All members share the same group code.

8. What are the demo credentials?

Email: admin@chama.com, Password: Admin@123, Group Code: CHAMA001.

9. Why am I seeing "Invalid email, password, or group code"?

One or more of the three fields is incorrect. Double-check spelling, including capital letters.

10. My account is locked. What do I do?

Too many failed login attempts lock your account for 15 minutes. Wait and try again.

11. I forgot my password. What can I do?

Click "Forgot password?" on the login page. The system creates a reset token, but does not email it. Contact your administrator for the reset link.

12. How do I change my password?

Go to Profile > Change Password. Enter your current and new password.

13. Can I stay logged in?

Check the "Remember me" box on login. This keeps you logged in for 30 days.

14. What if my account is suspended?

Contact your administrator to reactivate it.

Members

15. How do I add a new member?

Go to Members > Add New Member. Fill in the required fields (name, phone, join date) and save.

16. How are member numbers generated?

Automatically in the format CHM-YYYY-NNNN (e.g., CHM-2024-0001).

17. Can I delete a member?

Members are soft-deleted – their status becomes "Inactive" but the record stays in the database.

18. How do I edit a member's details?

Click the edit icon (pencil) next to the member in the list, update the fields, and save.

19. Can I upload a member's photo?

Yes. Edit the member and upload a photo (JPG/PNG/GIF, max 5 MB).

Contributions

20. How do I record a contribution?

Go to Contributions > Record Contribution, select the member and type, enter the amount, and save.

21. What is a contribution type?

A category (e.g., Monthly Savings, Welfare Fund) with its own amount and frequency.

22. Can I edit a contribution?

The current version does not support editing contributions.

23. What is a receipt number?

An auto-generated unique number for each contribution transaction (e.g., RCP-2024-0001).

24. How do I print a receipt?

Use your browser's Print function on the contributions list page.

Shares

25. What are shares?

Units of ownership in the group's investment pool. Members buy shares to invest.

26. How do I buy shares?

Go to Shares > Purchase Shares, select the member, product, and number of shares, then save.

27. What is a certificate number?

A unique number generated for each share purchase (e.g., CERT-2024-0001).

28. What share products are available?

Default products include Ordinary Shares (KSh 100 each) and Preference Shares (KSh 200 each).

Loans

29. How do I apply for a loan?

Go to Loans > Applications > New Application. Select the member, product, enter the amount and purpose, then submit.

30. What are the loan requirements?

The member must be active, the amount must be within the product limits, and the tenure must be within the product's range.

31. What is the difference between flat and reducing interest?

Flat interest is calculated on the full loan amount. Reducing balance interest is calculated on the outstanding amount, which decreases over time.

32. How do I add a guarantor?

During loan application, click "Add Guarantor" and select a member.

33. What is collateral?

An asset pledged as security for the loan (e.g., title deed, logbook).

34. How do I repay a loan?

Go to Loans > Repayments > Record Payment. Select the loan, enter the amounts, and save.

35. How is my loan balance calculated?

Initial amount minus principal payments made. Interest payments do not reduce the balance.

36. Can I see my repayment schedule?

Yes, open the loan detail page and click the "Schedule" tab.

37. What happens if I miss a payment?

A late penalty percentage may be applied based on the loan product settings.

38. How many loans can I have at once?

There is no system limit on the number of active loans per member.

Meetings

39. How do I schedule a meeting?

Go to Meetings > Schedule Meeting. Enter the title, date, time, venue, and agenda items.

40. How do I record attendance?

Open the meeting, click "Record Attendance", mark each member as present/absent/excused/late.

41. How do I record minutes?

Open the meeting, go to the Minutes tab, click "Record Minutes", and enter the content.

42. What meeting types are available?

Regular, Special, Annual, and Emergency.

43. Can I cancel a meeting?

Yes, change the meeting status to "Cancelled".

Messaging

44. How do I send a message?

Go to Messaging > Compose. Select a recipient, enter subject and body, then send.

45. Can I send a message to multiple people?

The current form allows only one recipient per message.

46. How do I know if someone read my message?

Check the Sent tab; read status is shown for recipients.

47. Can I delete a message?

The current version does not support deleting individual messages.

Announcements

48. How do I create an announcement?

Go to Announcements > New Announcement. Enter title, body, priority, and click Publish.

49. Can I edit an announcement?

No, delete it and create a new one.

50. How do I pin an announcement?

Check the "Pinned" box when creating it. Pinned announcements appear first.

Reports

51. What reports are available?

Contribution, Loan, Member, Meeting, and Financial reports.

52. How do I export a report?

Go to the report page, set filters, click "Export PDF".

53. Can I export to Excel?

No, only PDF export is available.

Accounting

54. What is a journal entry?

A double-entry record that debits one or more accounts and credits others by the same total.

55. What is a trial balance?

A report showing all accounts with their debit and credit totals to verify they balance.

56. How do I record an expense?

Go to Accounting > Expenses, click Add Expense, fill in the details, and save.

57. How do I record income?

Go to Accounting > Income, click Add Income, fill in the details, and save.

58. Can I manage bank accounts?

Yes, go to Accounting > Bank Accounts to add, edit, or delete accounts.

Settings and Administration

59. Who can change system settings?

Only Super Admin and Admin roles can access the Settings page.

60. How do I back up the database?

Go to Settings > Backup, click "Run Manual Backup".

61. How do I restore from a backup?

Use phpMyAdmin to import the backup SQL file.

62. What are audit logs?

A record of every change made in the system, including who made it, what was changed, and when.

Technical

63. What browsers are supported?

Chrome 90+, Firefox 88+, Edge 90+, Safari 14+, Opera 76+.

64. Why is the page slow?

Large datasets without filters can slow down queries. Use pagination and filters.

65. I see a blank white page. What happened?

A PHP error occurred. Check logs/error.log for details.

66. How do I clear the system cache?

The system does not cache data. Clear your browser cache (Ctrl+F5) if you see old data.

67. Can I run this on a live server?

Yes, upload the files to a PHP/MySQL web host and import the database.

68. What PHP version is required?

PHP 8.0 or higher.

69. What database is required?

MySQL 5.7+ or MariaDB 10.3+.

70. Is the system secure?

It uses prepared statements (PDO) for SQL queries, CSRF protection, password hashing (bcrypt), and session security.